Rajdhani Express passenger trains were first introduced in the late 1960s. Other trains until then used to run at a maximum speed of 100 kmph and the brief to run the fully air-conditioned train was to take the speed up to 120 kmph. It had a whole lot of critics and there was ‘objection after objection’ including from the then Railway Board chairman himself. [135] Doubts came from all quarters, including the Parliament.

Ashutosh K. Banerji, part of the select group at the Railways’ Research, Designs and Standards Organization (RDSO), which conceived and operationalized the Rajdhani, told me there were many objections but they were met with practical solutions. This is what Banerji, now 80, remembered and penned down promptly when I asked him to recollect the circumstances, the objections and the conditions under which the then fastest train—the Rajdhani Express—was allowed to run:

Objections

1. The Rajdhani would affect train operations, particularly that of freight trains, as it would need the same space required for three trains in front of it on the same track, given its speed. The steep speed differential between the Rajdhani and other trains would have to be taken into account. This would have an adverse effect on line capacity.
2. It would not be commensurate with the government’s policy of ushering in a socialistic pattern of society. It would be an elite service catering to the upper crust of society.
3. Air-conditioned travel in 1969 was considered a luxury. At that time somehow transporting the teeming millions was the primary objective.
4. Passenger comfort and amenities were not a priority area at that time. Movement of freight was. (India was then a growing nation with a number of industries being set up at that time, and railway freight was as important as passenger trains. The Rajdhani, at that time, was probably a fancy idea.)
5. The existing infrastructure, especially the railway tracks, and signalling, would not be able to support increased speeds. A massive upgrade of infrastructure with a stronger track structure and more reliable signalling needing substantial investments were required before increase in speed beyond the prevailing 100 kmph could be contemplated.